

DOT medical card · driver guide

For **John Doe** · Acme Trucking LLC

To operate a CMV in interstate commerce you must hold a current Medical Examiner's Certificate · physically dated by a DOT-certified examiner. Without it, you're out of service at the next inspection. This is the most common single OOS violation for drivers.

I · THE EXAM BASICS

- **Who can sign your card** · only a medical professional on the FMCSA National Registry of Certified Medical Examiners (NRCME). Verify them at nationalregistry.fmcsa.dot.gov before you spend money on the exam
- **Maximum certificate length** · 24 months · most drivers · [§391.43\(h\)](#)
- **Shorter certificates** · 1 year (controlled hypertension, sleep apnea on CPAP), 3 months (uncontrolled diabetes work-up), single-trip · the examiner decides
- **Cost** · typically \$80-150 · pay out of pocket unless employer covers

II · WHAT THE EXAMINER IS LOOKING AT

AREA	WHAT THEY CHECK	CFR
Vision	20/40 each eye + binocular · 70° peripheral · color vision (red, green, amber)	§391.41(b)(10)
Hearing	Forced whisper at 5 ft or 40 dB audiometric average at 500/1000/2000 Hz	§391.41(b)(11)
Blood pressure	< 140/90 ideal · 140-159/90-99 = 1 yr cert · 160-179/100-109 = 3 mo + recert	FMCSA guidance
Diabetes	Insulin-treated requires separate ITDM exemption · oral meds can be approved if A1c controlled	§391.46
Sleep apnea	BMI screening · CPAP compliance proof if treated · ≥4	MRB guidance

AREA	WHAT THEY CHECK	CFR
	hr/night $\geq 70\%$ of nights	
Cardiac history	Recent MI, bypass, defibrillator implant · wait periods + cardiologist clearance	§391.41(b)(4)
Mental health	Medication-controlled conditions usually OK · severe untreated conditions disqualify	§391.41(b)(8-9)
Substance use	Current alcoholism / drug use is disqualifying · SAP-cleared past use is OK	§391.41(b)(12-13)

III · THE EXAM DAY · WHAT TO BRING

1. **Driver license** · CDL or regular
2. **List of all medications** · prescription + OTC · including dosage
3. **Eyeglasses + contacts** · whichever you wear
4. **Hearing aids** · if you use them
5. **Specialist letters** · for any cardiac, diabetes, sleep apnea, mental health condition · the examiner needs the treating doctor's note saying you're stable
6. **CPAP compliance report** · download from your machine for the past 90 days · without it, sleep apnea drivers may not pass

IV · WHAT TO DO WITH THE CARD AFTER THE EXAM

1. **Take a photo of both sides** · keep on your phone
2. **Submit to your state CDL agency** · most states accept upload through the DMV portal · this updates your CDL with the new expiration · without this, your CDL goes to "not certified" status and you're OOS
3. **Give a copy to your safety director** · paper or scan · they need it for your DQ file within 24 hr of the exam
4. **Carry the original in your wallet or cab** · you can be asked for it at any roadside
5. **Calendar the next exam** · 60 days before expiration · don't wait until the last week

The single most common driver OOS: medical card expired and not noticed. Set the recert calendar reminder the day you walk out of the exam. X3 Compass tracks this automatically and pings you + your



carrier 60, 30, and 7 days out.